

HOW TO PREPARE FOR SUCCESSFUL TEACHING JOB INTERVIEWS AND DEMO LESSONS

A Full Course Lecture for Educators

Teacher Professional Development Programme

COURSE OVERVIEW AND OBJECTIVES

Securing a teaching position is one of the most significant professional transitions a teacher will make — whether they are entering the profession for the first time, moving between schools, or stepping into a new level of leadership. The teaching job interview is not simply a conversation; it is a professional performance, a values alignment exercise, and a mutual evaluation in which both candidate and school are determining whether a partnership of purpose is possible.

Yet despite its importance, most teacher education programmes devote little systematic attention to preparing candidates for the interview process. Many talented, well-prepared teachers underperform in interviews — not because they lack the professional knowledge or personal qualities the school is seeking, but because they have not understood the interview as a professional process requiring specific preparation, strategy, and skill.

This course addresses that gap comprehensively. It examines every stage of the teaching job application and interview process — from researching schools and crafting application documents, through preparing for panel interviews, to designing and delivering outstanding demonstration lessons. It draws on the perspectives of both candidates and selectors, on the psychology of impression formation, and on the practical wisdom of teachers and administrators who have been on both sides of the interview table.

By the end of this lecture, participants will be able to:

1. Research and evaluate prospective schools with professional sophistication.

2. Write compelling, distinctive application letters and prepare strong professional portfolios.
 3. Anticipate, prepare for, and respond excellently to the full range of teaching interview questions.
 4. Present themselves with confidence, authenticity, and professional credibility in panel interviews.
 5. Design and deliver outstanding demonstration lessons that showcase their best teaching.
 6. Handle challenging interview moments — unexpected questions, nerves, and technical difficulties — with composure and professionalism.
 7. Evaluate job offers thoughtfully and negotiate employment conditions appropriately.
 8. Reflect productively on both successful and unsuccessful interview experiences.
-

PART ONE: UNDERSTANDING THE TEACHING INTERVIEW PROCESS

1.1 What Schools Are Looking For

Before preparing for any interview, a candidate must understand, as precisely as possible, what the school is actually looking for. This requires moving beyond the generic — 'a passionate, dedicated teacher committed to student outcomes' — to the specific: What kind of teacher does this particular school, in this particular context, serving these particular students, most need right now?

School selection panels are typically assessing candidates across several dimensions simultaneously: professional knowledge (subject expertise and pedagogical understanding); teaching skill (demonstrated ability to plan, deliver, and assess learning effectively); personal qualities (communication, empathy, resilience, humour, and professional presence); values alignment (the degree to which the candidate's educational values match the school's philosophy and culture); collaborative capacity (the ability to work effectively with colleagues, students, and families); and growth orientation (evidence

that the candidate reflects on their practice and is committed to ongoing professional development).

Understanding these dimensions helps a candidate move from generic preparation ('I need to talk about my teaching philosophy') to targeted preparation ('I need to show this school specifically how my philosophy and practice align with their stated commitment to inquiry-based learning and their diverse student community').

"Before you can inspire, you must first understand. Before you can lead, you must first listen." — Winston Churchill

1.2 Types of Teaching Interviews

1.2.1 Panel Interviews

The most common format in school hiring is the panel interview — a formal conversation between the candidate and a group of selectors that typically includes the principal or head of school, a deputy or curriculum leader, a head of department, and sometimes a teacher representative or a community member. Panel interviews allow multiple perspectives on the candidate and reduce the risk of individual selector bias. They are typically structured around a set of pre-determined questions asked in sequence, with follow-up probing questions at selectors' discretion.

The panel interview demands a particular communication skill: the ability to address the whole panel — making genuine eye contact with each member, not only the questioner — while maintaining the conversational flow of a natural dialogue. Candidates who address only the most senior person in the room, or who address only the person who asked each question, miss the opportunity to build relationship with the whole panel.

1.2.2 Sequential or Serial Interviews

Some schools conduct sequential interviews — the candidate meets with several different people or groups in succession, each with a specific focus (curriculum knowledge, pastoral care, community engagement). This format is more common in larger schools and more senior positions. It requires the candidate to maintain consistent energy and coherence across multiple conversations while adapting their communication style to different audiences.

1.2.3 Informal Meetings and School Tours

Many schools precede the formal interview with an informal meeting — a school tour, a meeting with the department team, or a casual conversation over coffee. These interactions are not neutral preambles to the 'real' interview — they are part of the selection process, and the candidate is being assessed throughout. Engagement with students and staff during a school tour, the questions asked during an informal meeting, and the social ease demonstrated over coffee all provide selectors with valuable information about the candidate's professional presence and personal qualities.

1.2.4 Online and Hybrid Interviews

Video interviews — conducted via Zoom, Teams, or similar platforms — have become standard practice since 2020, either as a first-round screening tool or, in some cases, as the primary interview format. Online interviews present specific challenges: technical reliability, camera presence, managing the cognitive load of simultaneous speaking and monitoring one's own video feed, and the reduced social richness of mediated communication. They also present opportunities: the candidate controls their physical environment and can have notes discreetly available.

Preparation for online interviews requires specific attention: testing the technology well in advance; ensuring a professional, uncluttered background (or using a suitable virtual background); positioning the camera at eye level; ensuring adequate lighting from the front; and practising the specific cognitive skill of maintaining engaging eye contact with the camera rather than the screen.

1.3 The Selection Process as Mutual Evaluation

A critical and liberating reframing of the interview experience is to understand it as a mutual evaluation, not a one-way assessment. The school is evaluating whether the candidate is right for them — but the candidate is equally evaluating whether the school is right for them. This reframing reduces the power imbalance that produces interview anxiety, and it reminds candidates that their goal is not simply to be offered any job but to find a position in which they can thrive, grow, and do their best work.

This means that candidates should approach every aspect of the interview process — including the school tour, the informal conversations, the questions they are asked, and

the responses they observe — as data gathering. What do the interactions between staff tell you about the school's culture? What do the principal's answers to your questions reveal about their leadership style and values? Do the students you observe seem engaged, respected, and happy? Is this a place where you can be the teacher you want to be?

PART TWO: BEFORE THE INTERVIEW — RESEARCH AND PREPARATION

2.1 Researching the School

Deep, specific knowledge of the school you are applying to is the foundation of an outstanding interview performance. It enables you to speak concretely rather than generically, to connect your experience and philosophy to the school's specific context, and to ask intelligent, well-informed questions that signal serious professional interest.

Research should cover multiple dimensions:

2.1.1 The School's Mission, Values, and Culture

Read the school's website, annual report, strategic plan, and any published statements of educational philosophy with genuine attention. What does the school say it values? What kind of learning does it seek to create? What community does it serve? What are its stated priorities for improvement? Note specific language, specific programmes, and specific commitments that you can reference meaningfully in your interview.

Go beyond the official narrative. Look for the school's social media presence, news coverage, community reputation, and — where available — inspection or review reports. These sources often reveal aspects of the school's culture and priorities that the official website does not capture.

2.1.2 The Student Community

Understanding the school's student population — its demographic composition, socioeconomic profile, linguistic diversity, and any specific challenges or strengths it represents — is essential for demonstrating that you have genuinely thought about the specific teaching context, not simply submitted a generic application. A candidate who

can speak specifically about the needs and assets of the student community they would be joining demonstrates both professional seriousness and genuine interest in those students.

2.1.3 The Department and Curriculum

Research the specific department or year level you are applying to join. What curriculum does the school use? What assessment approaches does the department favour? Are there specific programmes, initiatives, or challenges that define the department's current work? If possible, speak with a current staff member — at a careers fair, through a professional network, or via LinkedIn — to get an insider perspective on the department's culture and priorities.

2.2 Crafting Your Application Documents

2.2.1 The Application Letter

The application letter — sometimes called a cover letter or letter of introduction — is the first text a selection panel reads about you. It is not a narrative version of your resume. It is a professional argument: a case, made in your own voice, for why you are the right person for this specific position in this specific school.

An outstanding application letter does five things: it opens compellingly (not with 'I am writing to apply for the position of...' but with a specific, vivid statement of professional commitment or identity); it demonstrates specific knowledge of the school and its context; it makes a clear, evidence-based case for your relevance to the school's specific needs; it conveys your educational philosophy and values with conviction and authenticity; and it closes with a confident expression of your interest in discussing the application further.

Every sentence should earn its place. Selection panels read many application letters, and a generic, formulaic letter — however technically competent — signals a candidate who has not taken the time to engage seriously with the specific opportunity. A specific, passionate, well-written letter signals the opposite.

2.2.2 The Professional Portfolio

A professional portfolio — a curated collection of evidence of your professional practice and growth — is an increasingly common requirement in teacher selection. A strong portfolio is not an archive (a collection of everything you have ever done) but a curated

argument (a carefully selected set of evidence that makes a specific case for your professional quality and your fit for this role).

A teaching portfolio typically includes: a statement of educational philosophy (a reflective, specific articulation of your beliefs about learning, teaching, and the purpose of education); evidence of planning (sample unit and lesson plans that demonstrate the quality and range of your instructional design); evidence of assessment practice (examples of assessment tasks, marking, and feedback that demonstrate your assessment literacy); evidence of student learning outcomes (where available and appropriately anonymised); evidence of professional development and learning; and examples of involvement in the wider school community.

Each item in the portfolio should be accompanied by a brief reflective commentary that explains what it demonstrates about your professional practice — not 'Here is a lesson plan' but 'This lesson plan demonstrates my approach to differentiated instruction and my use of formative assessment to adjust instruction in real time.'

2.2.3 The Resume or Curriculum Vitae

The teaching resume should be clean, well-organised, and tailored to the specific application. It typically includes: personal contact details; a brief professional summary or profile (two to three sentences capturing your professional identity and key strengths); teaching qualifications and certifications; employment history in reverse chronological order (with specific achievements, not merely role descriptions); professional development and learning; involvement in co-curricular, community, or leadership activities; and professional references.

Avoid common resume errors: excessive length (two to three pages is typically appropriate for early-career teachers; four to five for experienced teachers); vague, generic language ('dedicated to student success' tells selectors nothing); failure to quantify achievements where possible ('increased student engagement' is weaker than 'designed a project-based learning unit that increased student engagement scores from 62% to 84% on the school's wellbeing survey'); and failing to tailor the document to the specific application.

2.3 Preparing Your Interview Responses

Interview preparation is not about memorising scripted answers. It is about organising your professional knowledge, experience, and values into a repertoire of flexible, specific, compelling responses that you can adapt to the questions actually asked. The goal is to be so thoroughly prepared that you can be genuinely present — listening carefully, thinking authentically, and responding naturally — rather than anxiously searching your memory for the 'right' answer.

2.3.1 The STAR Technique

The STAR technique — Situation, Task, Action, Result — is the most widely recommended framework for structuring responses to behavioural interview questions ('Tell me about a time when...', 'Give me an example of...'). A STAR response moves through four stages:

9. **Situation:** Briefly describe the specific context — not a hypothetical or a generalisation, but a real, specific situation from your professional experience.
10. **Task:** Explain what your specific responsibility or challenge was in that situation.
11. **Action:** Describe, in concrete and specific detail, what you did — the decisions you made, the strategies you employed, the actions you took.
12. **Result:** Explain what happened as a result of your actions — what did students learn? What changed? What did you learn about your own practice?

The Result stage is where many candidates underperform — they describe the situation and action well but fail to connect their actions to specific, observable outcomes. Selectors want evidence that your professional decisions make a difference to students. Articulating that difference specifically and honestly — including what you would do differently in retrospect — is the mark of a reflective, evidence-oriented professional.

2.3.2 Preparing a Bank of Professional Stories

Because behavioural questions draw on your specific experience, the most efficient preparation strategy is to develop a bank of professional stories — detailed, reflective accounts of specific teaching experiences that illustrate key professional competencies. You need stories that demonstrate: effective lesson planning and delivery; differentiated instruction for diverse learners; successful assessment and feedback practice; management of challenging student behaviour; collaboration with colleagues;

communication with parents and families; response to professional setbacks or failures; and evidence of professional growth and learning.

Each story should be specific (a real event, not a composite), reflective (showing that you thought carefully about what happened and why), and outcome-focused (showing what your actions produced for students). A well-prepared bank of ten to fifteen professional stories gives you the raw material to respond compellingly to a very wide range of interview questions.

PART THREE: THE INTERVIEW — QUESTIONS, RESPONSES, AND PRESENCE

3.1 Common Categories of Interview Questions

3.1.1 *Philosophy and Values Questions*

These questions probe your fundamental educational beliefs and your understanding of the school's mission. They include: 'What is your philosophy of education?' 'What do you believe every student deserves from their schooling?' 'Why did you choose teaching as a profession?' 'What does outstanding teaching look like to you?'

Responses to philosophy questions should be specific, coherent, and genuinely yours — not a recitation of educational buzzwords. A philosophy is only convincing when it is expressed in your own language, grounded in specific examples from your experience, and connected explicitly to the school's context. 'I believe in high expectations for all students' is generic. 'I believe that every student, regardless of their starting point, deserves to be intellectually challenged — and I saw this belief tested and confirmed when I differentiated a Year 9 science unit for a class of thirty-two students ranging from Level 3 to Level 8 reading ability' is specific, convincing, and memorable.

3.1.2 *Pedagogical and Curriculum Questions*

These questions assess your professional knowledge of teaching and learning. They include: 'How do you plan a unit of work?' 'How do you differentiate instruction for students with varying needs?' 'How do you use assessment to inform your teaching?' 'How do you approach teaching students who are disengaged or significantly behind?'

Responses should demonstrate that you have genuine, sophisticated pedagogical knowledge — not just familiarity with the vocabulary ('I use formative assessment') but a specific, practical understanding of what that means in practice ('I use exit tickets at the end of each lesson to identify the two or three students who have not yet grasped the key concept, and I address their specific misconceptions in the first five minutes of the following lesson'). The difference between a candidate who knows the right words and one who has genuinely internalised effective practice is immediately apparent to experienced selectors.

3.1.3 Behaviour Management and Pastoral Questions

These questions assess your capacity to create and maintain productive learning environments and to support students' social and emotional wellbeing. They include: 'How do you establish expectations and routines at the start of the year?' 'Describe how you would respond to a student who persistently disrupts the class.' 'How would you approach a student who you suspected was experiencing difficulties at home?'

Responses should reflect a relational, proactive, and restorative orientation — demonstrating that you understand behaviour as communication, that you build relationships as your primary prevention strategy, and that you respond to behaviour with wisdom and care rather than reflexive punishment. Selectors will be alert to responses that sound punitive, rigid, or relationship-averse.

3.1.4 Collaboration and Collegial Questions

These questions assess your capacity to work effectively with colleagues. They include: 'How do you contribute to a team?' 'Describe a disagreement you had with a colleague and how you resolved it.' 'How do you give and receive professional feedback?' 'What would you contribute to this department beyond your classroom?'

Responses should demonstrate that you are genuinely collaborative — that you share resources, seek and offer feedback, are willing to disagree professionally, and contribute to the collective enterprise of school improvement. Schools do not hire teachers in isolation; they hire members of a professional community. Candidates who present as highly individualistic — brilliant in their own classroom but indifferent to the wider school — are a liability, not an asset.

3.1.5 Resilience and Challenge Questions

These questions probe your capacity to handle difficulty, failure, and professional stress. They include: 'Describe a lesson that did not go well and what you did about it.' 'Tell me about the most challenging student you have taught.' 'How do you manage the demands of the profession and maintain your own wellbeing?'

These are among the most revealing interview questions — and the most commonly mishandled. Candidates who present a flawless professional record signal either dishonesty or a lack of self-awareness. The selector is not looking for perfection; they are looking for evidence that you can face difficulty with honesty, learn from it productively, and emerge from it more capable. A candidate who can describe a genuine professional failure with clarity, self-compassion, and a clear account of what they learned is far more credible — and far more trustworthy as a colleague — than one who cannot recall ever making a significant mistake.

3.1.6 Questions About the School

Most interviews conclude with an invitation to ask questions. This is not a formality — it is a final opportunity to demonstrate your professional interest, your research, and your clarity about what you need in a professional environment to do your best work.

Excellent questions to ask selectors include: 'What does the school's professional development programme look like for early-career teachers?' 'How does the department use student learning data to improve curriculum and teaching?' 'What are the biggest challenges facing the school's student community right now?' 'How would you describe the culture of the department — how does the team work together and support each other?' 'What would success look like for the person in this role at the end of their first year?'

Questions to avoid: 'How many sick days do I get?' 'What is the starting salary?' 'Is there much after-school supervision duty?' These questions signal that your primary concern is your own comfort rather than the school's students — a signal that is very difficult to recover from.

3.2 Professional Presence in the Interview

3.2.1 *First Impressions and Non-Verbal Communication*

Research by psychologist Albert Mehrabian, while frequently misquoted, consistently supports the finding that non-verbal communication — facial expression, posture, gesture, eye contact, and vocal qualities — carries significant weight in interpersonal impression formation. In an interview context, selectors form strong impressions within the first few minutes of meeting a candidate — impressions that subsequently influence how they interpret the candidate's verbal responses.

Professional dress — appropriately formal for the school's culture, clean, and well-fitted — signals respect for the process and self-respect. An upright, open posture signals confidence and engagement. Genuine, warm eye contact — distributed across all panel members — signals interpersonal confidence and the capacity to build relationships. A measured, clear vocal tone — not too fast (anxiety), not too slow (disengagement), at appropriate volume — signals composure and communication skill. These are not tricks; they are the outward expressions of inner preparation and genuine professional confidence.

3.2.2 *Managing Interview Anxiety*

Interview anxiety is universal and, in moderate amounts, useful — it sharpens attention and motivates preparation. Severe anxiety, however, impairs performance: it narrows thinking, disrupts memory retrieval, and produces the physical symptoms — trembling voice, flushing, blank mind — that candidates most fear.

Research on performance anxiety suggests several evidence-based strategies: reappraisal (reinterpreting the physiological arousal of anxiety as excitement rather than fear); preparation (the most reliable anxiety reducer — the more thoroughly prepared you are, the more genuinely confident you will feel); controlled breathing (slow, deliberate diaphragmatic breathing activates the parasympathetic nervous system and reduces physiological arousal); and self-compassion (treating yourself with the kindness and understanding you would offer a friend in the same situation).

Practice is the single most powerful preparation for managing interview anxiety. Mock interviews — with a trusted colleague, a mentor, or even recorded solo — build familiarity

with the interview format, reveal gaps in your preparation, and develop the fluency that allows you to be genuinely present rather than anxiously performative.

3.2.3 Authenticity and Professionalism

One of the most common tensions candidates experience in interviews is between the desire to present their best professional self and the fear that doing so means being inauthentic — performing a role rather than being genuinely themselves. This tension dissolves when candidates understand that authentic professional presence is not about suppressing your personality but about expressing your professional self with confidence and intentionality.

The most memorable candidates are those who are simultaneously professionally credible (they clearly know their craft) and genuinely human (they express warmth, humour, passion, and honest self-awareness). They are not performing the role of 'ideal teacher candidate'; they are being the professional they actually are, at their best. This requires both thorough preparation and the courage to trust that who you genuinely are — with all your specific experience, your particular values, and your honest self-awareness — is enough.

PART FOUR: THE DEMONSTRATION LESSON

4.1 The Purpose and Stakes of the Demo Lesson

The demonstration lesson — a short teaching performance, typically twenty to forty minutes, delivered to a class of students (or sometimes to selectors role-playing as students) — is the most revealing and most high-stakes component of most senior teaching interviews. It is the moment at which all of a candidate's professional knowledge, pedagogical skill, interpersonal capacity, and personal presence are simultaneously visible.

A well-designed and expertly delivered demo lesson is the single most powerful thing a candidate can do to distinguish themselves in a competitive field. Conversely, a poorly designed or nervously delivered demo lesson — however good the panel interview — is very difficult to recover from. Understanding the demo lesson as a professional

performance requiring specific design and specific preparation is therefore among the most important insights this course offers.

"Teaching is a performing art — and like all performing arts, outstanding performance is the product of rigorous preparation." — Educational Leadership Research

4.2 Designing the Demo Lesson

4.2.1 Clarifying the Brief

Most schools provide a brief for the demo lesson: a topic, a year level, sometimes a specific curriculum standard. Before designing the lesson, clarify everything you can: What is the topic? What is the year level and approximate ability range? How long is the lesson? Will you be teaching real students or a panel of adults? Will you have access to technology? What resources are available? What has the class already been taught about this topic?

If you are not given this information proactively, ask — politely and specifically. A candidate who asks clarifying questions before designing a lesson is demonstrating exactly the kind of thoughtful, student-aware professional orientation that good schools are looking for. A candidate who designs a lesson without adequate information and then delivers it inappropriately demonstrates the opposite.

4.2.2 Selecting a Lesson Design Framework

For a demo lesson of twenty to forty minutes, a five-part lesson structure is typically most effective: a brief, engaging starter that activates prior knowledge or hooks attention; a clear introduction of the lesson's learning intentions; a focused section of new learning or exploration; guided and/or independent practice; and a brief, purposeful closure. Every element should be deliberately designed and purposefully connected to the others.

Given the brevity of the demo lesson, focus is essential. The most common demo lesson design error is attempting to cover too much content in too little time — producing a rushed, superficial experience that demonstrates breadth without depth. One concept, explored deeply, with genuine student thinking and interaction, is far more impressive than five concepts superficially surveyed.

4.2.3 Opening with Impact

The opening of your demo lesson sets the tone for everything that follows. An opening that immediately engages students' curiosity — a surprising fact, a provocative question, a brief video clip, a real-world scenario, a physical object or image — signals a teacher who understands motivation and who has genuine enthusiasm for their subject. An opening that begins with 'Today we are going to learn about...' followed by teacher-directed note-taking signals the opposite.

The hook should connect authentically to the lesson's learning goals. It should generate genuine curiosity or productive confusion that the lesson's learning will resolve. And it should communicate, in the first thirty seconds, that this teacher is someone worth paying attention to.

4.2.4 Building Student Interaction and Thinking

The demo lesson is not an opportunity to deliver your best lecture. It is an opportunity to demonstrate your capacity to facilitate genuine student thinking, engagement, and learning. The most impressive demo lessons are characterised by high levels of purposeful student activity: students thinking, discussing, writing, investigating, creating, and demonstrating their understanding — not passively receiving information from the teacher.

Design at least two to three specific interaction points into your lesson: a Think-Pair-Share to generate initial thinking, a brief group task that applies new learning to a specific problem, a targeted questioning sequence that draws out and extends student thinking, or a brief independent practice task with immediate teacher feedback. These interactions should be structured (students know exactly what to do), purposeful (they advance the lesson's learning goals), and timed (the teacher maintains appropriate pace and momentum).

4.2.5 Demonstrating Differentiation

Selectors of teaching candidates are acutely alert to whether the candidate can teach the range of learners in a real classroom — not only the students who are already engaged and performing well, but those who are struggling, those who are significantly advanced, and those who are disengaged or anxious. Even in a brief demo lesson, you should demonstrate awareness of and responsiveness to the diversity of learners before you.

This might mean: asking questions at different cognitive levels so that every student has an accessible entry point; providing a brief extension task for students who complete the main activity early; using a scaffolded graphic organiser for students who need additional structure; or noticing during a pair activity that a particular student is struggling and providing them with specific, targeted support. These actions do not need to be elaborate — but they need to be genuine and specific enough to demonstrate that you are actually attending to individual learners, not performing to the selectors.

4.2.6 Closing with Consolidation

The closure of your demo lesson should consolidate and connect the learning — not simply announce that time is up. A well-designed closure might ask students to write one key thing they learned and one question they still have; to apply the lesson's concept to a brief new example; to connect today's learning to something they already knew; or to respond to a single exit ticket question that requires them to demonstrate the lesson's key understanding.

The closure is also your opportunity to demonstrate metacognitive teaching — making the learning process itself visible. Naming what students have learned, connecting it to where they are going, and inviting students to reflect on how their thinking has developed during the lesson positions you as a teacher who is conscious not only of content but of learning itself.

4.3 Delivering the Demo Lesson

4.3.1 Building Rapport Quickly

One of the most extraordinary demands of the demo lesson is the requirement to build genuine, warm rapport with a class of students you have never met — within the first two to three minutes of the lesson. This is a skill that experienced teachers develop over years of beginning new school years, meeting new classes, and building relationships from scratch. For the demo lesson, it requires deliberate, specific attention.

Strategies for building rapid rapport include: greeting students warmly and individually as they arrive; using students' names as quickly as possible (ask, write them down, use them immediately); showing genuine interest in students' prior knowledge or experience; demonstrating authentic enthusiasm for the lesson's content; using humour appropriately

and naturally; and communicating, through your body language and attention, that you are genuinely glad to be in the room with these particular students.

4.3.2 Managing the Unexpected

In a demo lesson, unexpected things will happen — a student who is disruptive, a piece of technology that fails, a concept that produces more confusion than expected, a class that is more advanced or less advanced than the brief suggested. How a candidate responds to these moments is often the most revealing part of the demo lesson for selectors — it shows them the professional who will be in their school on a difficult Tuesday afternoon, not merely the polished performer in an optimal environment.

The key principles for managing the unexpected are: stay calm (your composure is infectious; if you panic, the lesson derails; if you remain steady, it does not); be honest (if the technology fails, acknowledge it simply and calmly and continue without it; do not pretend it hasn't happened); be flexible (have a Plan B — a backup activity, a paper-based alternative — that you can deploy without drama); and keep the focus on students (whatever else is happening, the students in front of you are your primary responsibility).

4.3.3 Reflecting After the Demo

Many schools ask candidates to reflect on their demo lesson — either immediately afterwards in a brief conversation with selectors, or as part of the debrief discussion. This is not a formality; it is a significant component of the selection process. A candidate who can reflect honestly and specifically on their demo lesson — naming what worked well and why, identifying what they would do differently, connecting both to specific moments in the lesson rather than generic self-evaluation — is demonstrating the reflective practice that is the engine of professional growth.

Avoid two common errors: excessive self-criticism ('It was terrible, I'm so sorry') and defensive self-protection ('I thought it went really well'). The selector is not looking for either performance or defensiveness; they are looking for the honest, specific, growth-oriented professional reflection that characterises excellent teachers. 'I was pleased with the level of student discussion during the Think-Pair-Share — I heard some genuinely sophisticated thinking. I would change the closure — I ran out of time and students didn't

have the opportunity to consolidate their learning, which I would address by trimming the exploration activity by three minutes' is specific, balanced, and professionally credible.

PART FIVE: AFTER THE INTERVIEW

5.1 Following Up Professionally

After the interview, a brief, professional thank-you communication — a short email to the principal or panel chair, sent within twenty-four hours — is appropriate in most professional cultures. It should express genuine appreciation for the opportunity, reaffirm your interest in the position, and — if there is something specific you wish to add or clarify from the interview — do so briefly and naturally. It should not be a second application letter; it should be a brief, warm, professional courtesy.

5.2 Evaluating the Offer

If you receive an offer, take the time to evaluate it thoughtfully before accepting. The right questions to ask include: Does this school's culture, values, and professional environment match what I need to do my best work? Is the professional development offer sufficient for my stage of career? Are the employment conditions — salary, class load, co-curricular responsibilities — acceptable? Do I feel confident about the leadership? Will I have genuine colleagues — people I can learn from and contribute to?

Accepting a teaching position is not merely a financial transaction; it is a professional and personal commitment to a specific community of students, colleagues, and families. Taking it seriously — giving it the reflective thought it deserves — is a professional responsibility as well as a personal one.

5.3 Negotiating Conditions

Beginning teachers, in particular, often accept whatever conditions are offered without negotiation — sometimes from fear, sometimes from inexperience, sometimes from a genuine lack of knowledge about what is negotiable. In most systems, starting salary is determined by a published scale based on qualifications and experience, and is not negotiable. However, other conditions — class allocation, co-curricular expectations,

professional development entitlements, the nature of mentoring support for beginning teachers — may be open to discussion.

Negotiation in a professional context requires clarity about what you need, the courage to ask for it respectfully, and the wisdom to distinguish between the non-negotiable and the flexible. A candidate who asks clearly and professionally for what they need — 'I am very keen to accept this position, and I would like to confirm the professional development allocation for beginning teachers' — demonstrates the self-awareness and professional confidence that good schools value. A candidate who accepts everything without question and then resents the conditions they agreed to is serving neither themselves nor the school.

5.4 Learning from Rejection

Not every interview produces an offer — and responding to rejection with professional grace and genuine self-reflection is a mark of professional maturity. If you are not offered a position, request feedback from the selection panel wherever possible. Good selection panels will provide specific, honest feedback on your interview and demo lesson performance — feedback that is among the most valuable professional development you will receive.

Receive this feedback with gratitude and genuine openness, not defensiveness. Even if you disagree with some of what you hear, consider it seriously. The selectors have seen a great many candidates and have a clear picture of what effective teaching in their context looks like. Their perspective on your performance is professional data — and professional data, honestly received and carefully considered, is the raw material of improvement.

PART SIX: SPECIAL CONTEXTS AND CONSIDERATIONS

6.1 The Beginning Teacher's Interview

Beginning teachers face a specific challenge in the interview process: they have limited professional experience to draw on for STAR-format responses, and they may not yet have developed a fully articulated professional philosophy. They also bring significant

strengths that are sometimes undervalued: recent, research-informed teacher education; familiarity with current curriculum developments; enthusiasm and energy; and the particular gift of a 'beginner's mind' — openness to learning and growth unencumbered by entrenched habits.

Beginning teachers should draw confidently on practicum and student teaching experience, voluntary and community work with young people, observations of experienced teachers, and their own experience as learners. They should be honest about their career stage — selectors know they are interviewing a beginning teacher and are looking for potential, orientation, and honesty, not the polished performance of a ten-year veteran.

6.2 The Experienced Teacher's Interview

Experienced teachers face a different challenge: the risk that confidence shades into complacency, that the professional comfort of established practice obscures the genuine excitement and growth that schools are looking for in their new appointments. An experienced teacher who presents as having nothing more to learn — who cannot describe their most recent professional challenge or articulate what they most want to develop — is a red flag for a thoughtful selection panel.

Experienced teachers should emphasise specific, evidence-informed impact ('In my current school, I led the redesign of the Year 10 history curriculum, which produced a 23-percentage-point improvement in student achievement on the state assessment over two years'); demonstrate genuine growth orientation ('The area I am most actively working on is improving the quality of peer feedback in my classroom — I have been reading Dylan Wiliam's work and experimenting with structured peer assessment protocols'); and communicate specific reasons for their interest in the new school that go beyond general statements of professional ambition.

6.3 Leadership and Senior Position Interviews

Interviews for leadership positions — head of department, year-level coordinator, deputy principal — require an additional dimension of preparation: demonstrating not only excellent classroom practice but the capacity to lead, develop, and inspire others. Leadership interview questions will probe your understanding of school improvement

processes, your experience of leading curriculum development or professional learning, your approach to performance management and staff development, and your vision for the role you are seeking.

Leadership candidates should be able to articulate a clear, evidence-informed vision for the role ('In my first year as head of department, my priorities would be: establishing a shared understanding of what excellent teaching looks like in our subject, building a culture of collaborative lesson design, and implementing a consistent approach to assessment and moderation'); demonstrate specific leadership experience with measurable outcomes; and show genuine curiosity about and respect for the people they would be leading.

CONCLUSION

The teaching job interview is not an obstacle between you and your career — it is the beginning of your professional relationship with a school community. Approached with the same rigour, intentionality, and genuine human engagement that characterise outstanding teaching, it becomes an opportunity not only to secure a position but to model, in miniature, the professional you are and the teacher you will be.

This course has guided you through every stage of that process: from the deep school research that grounds a compelling application, through the preparation of professional stories and the articulation of your philosophy, to the management of interview anxiety and the design and delivery of an outstanding demonstration lesson. It has examined the interview from both sides of the table, and it has connected every aspect of interview preparation to the broader professional practice of which it is an expression.

The most important preparation you can undertake for a teaching interview is to be, and to keep becoming, an excellent teacher — because the candidate who performs best is not the one who has most cleverly packaged themselves for interview success, but the one whose preparation has simply made their genuine professional excellence visible. That is what selectors are looking for. That is what students deserve. And that is what this course — and all the courses in this programme — is ultimately about.

| *"The best way to predict your future is to create it." — Abraham Lincoln*

RECOMMENDED FURTHER READING AND RESOURCES

- Lemov, D. (2010). *Teach Like a Champion*. Jossey-Bass. (Practical teaching techniques applicable to demo lesson design.)
 - Wiliam, D. (2011). *Embedded Formative Assessment*. Solution Tree Press. (For demonstrating assessment literacy in interview responses.)
 - Dweck, C. (2006). *Mindset: The New Psychology of Success*. Random House. (For articulating a growth-oriented professional philosophy.)
 - Hattie, J. (2012). *Visible Learning for Teachers*. Routledge. (For grounding interview responses in research evidence.)
 - Noddings, N. (2005). *The Challenge to Care in Schools* (2nd ed.). Teachers College Press. (For articulating a relational, caring educational philosophy.)
 - Covey, S.R. (1989). *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*. Simon & Schuster. (Habit 5 — 'Seek first to understand' — is particularly applicable to the interview context.)
 - Rock, D. (2009). *Your Brain at Work*. HarperBusiness. (For understanding and managing interview anxiety through neuroscience.)
 - Tomlinson, C.A. (2001). *How to Differentiate Instruction in Mixed-Ability Classrooms* (2nd ed.). ASCD. (For demonstrating differentiation in demo lesson design.)
-

— *End of Lecture* —